Israeli-Palestinian Conflict (A Collection)

By Elana Bell, Yehuda Amichai, Nadine Murtaja, Naomi Shihab Nye and Rabbi Tamara Cohen

Your Village by Elana Bell

Once in a village that is burning
because a village is always somewhere burning

And if you do not look because it is not your village
it is still your village

In that village is a hollow child
You drown when he looks at you with his black,
black eyes

And if you do not cry because he is not your child
he is still your child

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Elana Bell
Book: Eyes, Stones
ISBN: 978-0807144640
Publisher: LSU Press
Date (Month/Year): April 2012

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INTRODUCTION

Poetry, by its nature, is a form of dialogue; an attempt to communicate. In the throes of the Palestinian-Israeli conflict that has lasted more than 70 years – in societies politically torn apart -- the need to communicate across political and cultural boundaries is particularly intense.

Spoken word poet Mohammed Moussa describes the reality of Gaza today: "life here is poetry blown into pieces and scattered all over the place. In the weddings, there's poetry, in times of war, in the eyes of an old man sitting in front of his small shop, mourning the death of his child, in the flames of bombs falling . . . poetry blown to pieces.

if you do not look because it is not your village
it is still your village

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The Diameter of a Bomb by Yehuda Amichai

The diameter of the bomb was thirty centimeters

and the diameter of its effective range about seven meters,

with four dead and eleven wounded.

And around these, in a larger circle

of pain and time, two hospitals are scattered

and one graveyard. But the young woman

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who was buried in the city she came from,
at a distance of more than a hundred kilometers,
enlarges the circle considerably,
and the solitary man mourning her death
at the distant shores of a country far across the sea
includes the entire world in the circle.
And I won't even mention the crying of orphans
that reaches up to the throne of God and
beyond, making a circle with no end and no God.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Yehuda Amichai
Book: The Selected Poetry of Yehuda Amichai
ISBN: 978-0520205383
Publisher: University of California Press
Date (Month/Year): Oct 1996

Untitled by Nadine Murtaja

There, on the other side,
time changes, hours pass, and it gets darker,
the sky takes off its dim dress, then the morning arrives,

But here where I live, and breathe, life wears its black dress
constantly,

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To mourn the labor of my land
Which took a long time.

Here, the hanging clock, in my room is broken,
not only this one, everyone's clock is broken here,
my mother keeps saying:
everyone is waiting for the elixir,
we've had it with the grief and agony,

in this holy land we sleep and wake up to the sound of bombing and shooting
so the first light of day rises in the evening,
lighting up the sky with the blood of martyrs,
here death sleeps not far from us,
we all walk towards freedom, towards hope,
we walk on the shattered glass of our broken windows,
we walk on stones that once were a house, carrying stories and secrets,
we walk with the screams of children, and the groans of mothers pulsating over and over in our ears.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Nadine Murtaja
ISBN: On-line Transcript
Publisher: Aljazeera.com
Date (Month/Year): June 8 2021

https://www.aljazeera.com/features/2021/6/8/as-the-bombs-fall-i-write-the-poets-of-gaza

Kindness by Naomi Shihab Nye

Before you know what kindness really is
you must lose things,
feel the future dissolve in a moment
like salt in a weakened broth.
What you held in your hand,
what you counted and carefully saved,
all this must go so you know
how desolate the landscape can be
between the regions of kindness.
How you ride and ride
thinking the bus will never stop,
the passengers eating maize and chicken
will stare out the window forever.
Before you learn the tender gravity of kindness
you must travel where the Indian in a white poncho
lies dead by the side of the road.
You must see how this could be you,
how he too was someone
who journeyed through the night with plans
and the simple breath that kept him alive.
Before you know kindness as the deepest thing inside,
you must know sorrow as the other deepest thing.
You must wake up with sorrow.
You must speak to it till your voice
catches the thread of all sorrows
and you see the size of the cloth.
Then it is only kindness that makes sense anymore,
only kindness that ties your shoes
and sends you out into the day to gaze at bread,
only kindness that raises its head
from the crowd of the world to say
It is I you have been looking for,
and then goes with you everywhere
like a shadow or a friend.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Naomi Shihab Nye
Book: Words Under the Words: Selected Poems
ISBN: 978-0933377295
Publisher: The Eighth Mountain Press
Date (Month/Year): Oct 1994

No Pain Like My Pain by Rabbi Tamara Cohen

"Look carefully and see if there could possibly be pain like my pain, like the one bestowed by You upon me."

No pain like my pain,
no exile like my exile,
No land my land,
No desolate city like my desolate city.
No heart like my own aching heart.
No fear like the fear of my people.
No genocide like our genocide.
No humanity like our humanity.
No right like our right.
No wrong like their wrong.
No rage like my rage.

No pain like my pain,
immediate and raw and righteous,
ancient and true and etched in our genes by history's injustices.

Dear God, help us look,
look closer so that we may see
our children in their children,
their children in our own.

Help us look so that we may see You –
in the bleary eyes of each orphan, each grieving childless mother,
each masked and camouflaged fighter for his people's dignity.

Dear God, Divine Exiled and Crying One,
Loosen our claim to our own uniqueness.
Soften this hold on our exclusive right – to pain, to compassion, to justice.

May your children, all of us unique and in Your image,
come to know the quiet truths of shared pain,

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shared hope,

shared land,

shared humanity,

shared risk,

shared courage,

shared peace.

In Sh'Allah. Ken yehi Ratzon.

May it be Your will.

And may it be ours.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Rabbi Tamara Cohen
ISBN: On-line Transcript
Publisher: Ritualwell.org

https://www.ritualwell.org/ritual/no-pain-my-pain

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